

Jones vs. Alfred H. Mayer Co.

In 1968, Joseph Lee Jones tried to buy a home in the Paddock Woods community of St. Louis County, Missouri. Alfred H. Mayer, who represented the Alfred Realty Company, refused to sell the home to Jones. Jones claimed that the sole reason he was denied the sale was because of his race (African American). This was not denied by Mayer, who claimed the right to decide who purchased the property in a private sale.

The district court ruled in favor of Mayer, saying that the federal law that protected discrimination in housing applied only to state action and did not apply to individual owners' private refusals to sell.

The U.S. Supreme Court disagreed with the district court's interpretation and stated that it applies to all sales and rentals, even private ones, and it would bring the law in line with the 14th Amendment, which addresses citizenship rights and equal protection under the law.

This decision had far-reaching effects, because it stated definitively that racial discrimination is not allowed in any sale of property within the U.S. The decision also gave the Congress authority under the 13th Amendment to regulate against racial discrimination.